PEELIN

A shedding duel for two with the Trifle deck.
Stake a card on going out, peel your hand, and free your Queens.

Designed by Jonathan Ratschat

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Concept

Peelin is a shedding game for two. You may never rearrange your hand. You lead only from its left or right side, but you may beat with cards from anywhere. The Queens are the strongest cards, but a Queen must reach a side before you can play it.

When you pass, you may **pick** a card from your opponent's combination and put it anywhere into your hand.

Before play, both players secretly **stake** one card on going out. A Queen is a big bet but leaves your hand weaker. A 0 is a safe bet and takes a weak card out of your hand.

When a player goes out, they score **points** for every card left in their opponent's hand and for both stakes. Each card is worth its rank, and a Queen is worth 10. The first player to reach the target score wins.

Setup

Players: 2.

Cards: One Trifle deck of **28 cards**: 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, and a Queen in each of the four suits.

Without a Trifle deck: From a standard deck, take the Jacks, Aces, 2–5, and Queens. Jacks count as 0 and Aces as 1. From a numbered deck such as Sticheln, take 0–5 and the 10 in four colors. The 10 counts as the Queen.

Keeping score: Pen and paper, or poker chips as counters.

Dealer: Randomly choose the dealer for the first deal. After that, the player with the **higher score** deals, so the player who is behind leads. If the scores are tied, the player who went out in the last deal deals.

Deal: Shuffle all 28 cards and deal **12 cards** to each player. Place the last **4 cards** face down to one side. These **unused cards** stay face down and are not used.

Your hand: Pick up your 12 cards as a stack and fan them out **without changing their order**. You may never rearrange your hand.

A Deal at a Glance

1. **Deal:** 12 cards each, 4 unused cards face down. Never rearrange your hand.
2. **Stake:** Both players place one card from anywhere in their hand face down at the same time.
3. **Tricks:** The non-dealer leads. Beat the last combination with an equal or higher one of the same type, or pass. Lead from one side of your hand, beat from anywhere. Queens always come from a side.
4. **Pick:** When you pass, you may put one card of the last combination anywhere into your hand.
5. **Going out:** The deal ends as soon as a player plays their last card.
6. **Scoring:** The player who went out scores points for the cards left in their opponent's hand and for both stakes.

Cards

Rank: $0 < 1 < 2 < 3 < 4 < 5 <$ Queen.

Suits play no role in Peelin.

Points: Each card from 0 to 5 is worth its rank, and each Queen is worth 10.

Stake

After the deal, both players take one card from anywhere in their hand and place it face down in front of them at the same time. This card is their **stake**. Each player now has **11 cards** in hand. Your stake is not part of your hand and cannot be played. You may look at it at any time.

Any card may be your stake, including a Queen.

Combinations

There are three types of combination, listed in Table 1. A combination is beaten by an equal or higher combination of the same type.

Table 1: Combinations

Type	Cards
Single	Any one card.
Pair	Two adjacent cards of the same rank.
Run	Two adjacent cards of consecutive rank from 0–5, in either order. No Queens.

Adjacent: Two cards are adjacent if they are next to each other in your hand. When a card leaves the middle of your hand, the cards on both sides of the gap become adjacent.

Leading from a side: When you lead, you may only play from the left or right side of your hand. A single must be your leftmost or rightmost card. A pair or run must be your two leftmost or two rightmost cards.

Beating from anywhere: When you beat, you may play any single, or any two adjacent cards, from anywhere in your hand.

Queens: A Queen can only be played from a side of your hand, also when beating. A pair of Queens must be your two leftmost or your two rightmost cards.

Runs: Both 3-4 and 4-3 are runs. A run ranks by its higher card. Queens can never be part of a run, so the highest run is 4-5.

Example: Your hand is 2 3 Q 5 0 0, from left to right. You may lead the single 2, the single 0, the run 2-3, or the pair 0-0. You cannot lead the Queen or the 5. You may beat with the 5, but not with the Queen, because it is not on a side. If you beat a single with the 5, the Queen and the 0 become adjacent.

Tricks

Players take turns. A **trick** is a series of combinations that ends when a player passes. The non-dealer leads the

first trick.

Leading: Play any combination from one side of your hand. The leader cannot pass.

Your turn after a lead: Do one of the following:

- **Beat** the last combination with an equal or higher combination of the same type, from anywhere in your hand.
- **Pass**. You may pass even if you could beat the last combination.

Example: Your opponent leads a single 3. You may beat it with another 3, a 4, a 5, or a Queen from a side of your hand.

When a player passes:

1. The passing player may pick a card (see **Pick**).
2. All other cards of the trick go face down on a discard pile. Nobody may look through it.
3. The player who played the last combination leads the next trick.

Pick

When you pass, you may take **one card** from the last combination played and put it anywhere into your hand, including on either side.

Example: Your hand is 2 3 Q 5 0 0. You lead the pair 0-0, your opponent beats it with 4-4, and you pass. You pick a 4 and put it between the Queen and the 5: 2 3 Q 4 5. The run 4-5 is now on your right side.

Going Out

You **go out** when you play your last card. The deal ends at once.

Scoring

At the end of each deal, both players reveal their stake. The player who went out scores the points of all cards left in their opponent's hand and of **both** stakes. The other player scores nothing.

Your **score** is the total of your points over all deals.

Example: A goes out with a 4 as stake. B still holds a Queen, a 3, and a 0, and staked a 2. A scores 10 + 3 + 0 + 4 + 2 = 19. B scores nothing.

Game End

Play to **100 points**, to **50 points** for a short match, or to any agreed number of deals or points. The first player to reach the **target score** wins.

With an agreed number of deals, the higher score wins. A tie goes to the player who went out in the last deal.

Design Notes and Credits

Peelin started as a challenge to myself. Jacob Landrum's The Blueberry Score brought me to Sean Ross's Trifle deck, and I wanted to find out whether its 28 cards could also carry a shedding game. Additional inspiration came from Jonathan Cox's Spring Cleaning and Zoë Cappallo's Deque. Thanks to Sean for opening up the deck so generously to other designers.

Special thanks to all playtesters and everyone who helped improve Peelin, especially Tanja Simic, Matthias Gilch, Bryce Carter, and freebird.

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PEELiN Player Reference

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Cards

Rank: 0 < 1 < 2 < 3 < 4 < 5 < Queen. Suits play no role.

Card	Points
0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5	Same as rank
Queen	10

Stake

One card from anywhere in your hand, face down, at the same time. Revealed at the end of the deal.

Combinations

Lead from one side of your hand: your leftmost or rightmost card, or your two leftmost or two rightmost cards. **Beat** with any single or any two adjacent cards from anywhere in your hand. **Queens** always come from a side. A combination is beaten by an equal or higher one of the same type. A run ranks by its higher card.

Type	Cards
Single	Any one card.
Pair	Two adjacent cards of the same rank.
Run	Two adjacent cards of consecutive rank from 0–5, in either order. No Queens.

Tricks

Beat the last combination with an equal or higher one of the same type, or pass. The leader cannot pass. A pass ends the trick. The passing player may pick one card of the last combination and put it anywhere into their hand. The player who played last leads next.

Scoring

The player who went out scores the points of all cards left in their opponent's hand plus **both** stakes. The other player scores nothing.

Match: Play to 100 points, or 50 for a short match. The player with the higher score deals next, so the player behind leads. The first player to reach the target score wins.